



June 2024

Engagement Proposal

Prepared for
Stellar Roots

Presented by
Jade Rabbit
Alita Kelly

Jade Rabbit

Jade Rabbit is a business with a mission to shape the future through intentional planning and action. We do this through strategic planning + design, urban agriculture development, and curating unique experiences. We work through the lens of sustainability + equity at the core of everything we do and look to nature and our collective ancestors to inspire and guide us.

Meet our team

Alita Kelly

Founder + Alchemist

12 years experience



Sergio Cira

Strategist

16 years experience





Our
Work
Thus Far

2020 + Before

in Review

Community Nutrition

Alita started her career in food systems work coordinating Access of West Michigan's prescription for health program. Followed by that was a 3 year stint as the first Nutrition Director for D.A. Blodgett - St. John's residential home for children. In both roles she received great experience doing program design while helping integrate her passion for healthy food access and local food together in roles supporting people experiencing food insecurity. The food waste she witnessed encouraged her to switch gears from nutrition to sustainability within the food ecosystem. During this time Alita also started a catering business called Royal Jelly, working with local farms to create healthy version of homestyle favorites. The business won the people's choice award through the Michigan Good Food Fund during a public vote.

Urban Agriculture Policy

Alita has been working with the Grand Rapids Urban Agriculture Committee since its inception in 2017. She took a hiatus while she finished her degree in Environmental Science + Sustainable Business from the University of Michigan but promptly reinstated her participation after graduation. She eventually served as Vice Chair and then Chair of the group while they drafted what will be the city's first ever local urban agriculture municipal policy. Alita has also volunteered for the Urban Forestry's subcommittee contributing to the city's upcoming policy regarding how people grow in the green space between the sidewalk and street.

Freedom School

In the summer of 2020, Alita launched a program called Freedom School as a way to empower children and educators with a unique experience where agriculture and social justice meet. The first iteration of this grassroots initiative was run out of Alita's home and funded by the City of Grand Rapids Neighborhood Match Program as well as a GoFundMe campaign. Alita was inspired to launch the enrichment program as an ode to the Freedom School's of the 60's and a way for the community to explore perseverance through COVID with a fractured food supply and a social justice renaissance in the aftermath of George Floyd's death.



First cohort of Freedom Schoolers planting garlic in 2020 in SE Grand Rapids

2020 In Review

South East Market + Entrepreneurship

After years of deliberation, Alita launched South East Market a grocery store rooted in the principles of food sovereignty in the summer of 2020. The store launched thanks to a successful GoFundMe campaign that raised over \$30k and a very intentional marketing and community engagement strategy was crafted. The market's evolution was a labor of love by several stakeholders and it employed several innovative measures to address its ambitious goals. A few unique measures that Alita created to help the market address its mission to increase access to healthy, affordable, culturally appropriate food through a sustainable + equitable lens include:

- Developing a produce subscription model that helped leverage consumer investment to provide secure sales for local farms.
- Developing mutual aid frameworks to leverage customers with extra means to support the nutritional needs of customers experiencing food insecurity.
- Partnering with several community organizations to increase the quality of food provided to their clients experiencing food insecurity and working with them to facilitate a more dignified experience.
- Working with several local food vendors and farm businesses to bring their products to market, providing additional business support measures for businesses to scale and move into larger retail markets including fundraising strategies, business plan support, marketing plans, etc.
- Creating ways to reduce food waste such as adopting a compost system in partnership with Wormies to redirect all organic food waste from going to the landfill.

Alita sold her shares of South East Market in early 2023 but the business has been recognized with several awards and recognitions for its innovative model and community impact.



2021 in Review

MLK Community Garden

Grand Rapids Parks and Recreation Department co-created the MLK Park Community Garden with Alita as head of the project and garden manager in 2021. The 6 boxes installed by the community were home to workshops and the rapidly evolving Freedom School program. Together the garden and Freedom School began to create place and enhance purpose for residents while expanding the area's health assets, an invaluable measure for an area that needs increased investment to positively address neighbors social determinants of health. In the first year of gardening at MLK Park we troubleshooted several issues as they arose which led to more efficient production in the following years. In 2021 Alita partnered with the Dreams Take Work camp to facilitate a weekly Freedom School enrichment class for campers over 10 weeks.



Check out this story in
Rapid Growth Media
highlighting this work



West Michigan Young Farmers + Land Fund

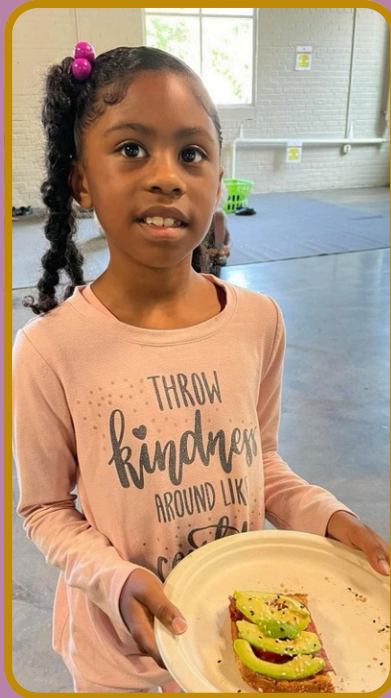
Alita was approached by the National Young Farmers Coalition to help launch a West Michigan Chapter to strengthen support for young and BIPOC farmers in the area and help leverage those farmers for federal policy change. Alita along with 4 other growers started the chapter with a local goal of increasing equitable land access for BIPOC growers. The chapter started the West Michigan Farmer of Color Land fund, a mutual aid project with a goal to provide funds for BIPOC growers to acquire land or hold on to land. The fund just reached its goal and plans to make the first awards in 2024!



Check out more
information about
the Land Fund here!

2022 in Review

Farm to School with Michigan Department of Education



In 2022 Alita was approached by the Michigan Department of Education to help connect local farms to schools through the USDA Team Nutrition Program. Jade Rabbit and Taste the Local Difference's role in this project is acting as farmer liaisons connecting 25 farms to 50 schools across the state. Jade Rabbit helps to empower strong relationships building between farms and schools as well as designing systems and providing strategy to ensure that when the Team Nutrition grant that funds this work ends (May 2024) communities will still benefit. Jade Rabbit covers Grand Rapids and Detroit among other areas through this initiative. Farm to School efforts are important to us because growing food is the first step to supporting our community with food access but getting it to them where they live, learn, work, and play is an essential piece of the puzzle.

Urban Agriculture in Grand Rapids + USDA

In 2022, Jade Rabbit partnered with Power to the People 616, formally signed a contract with the city of Grand Rapids to maintain the garden. Freedom School became its own program with its own outreach and dedicated students. The integration of workshops at MLK and additional site of Garfield Park started and Freedom School began to take field trips to local agricultural and environmental sites. Refinement of curriculum was developed through a USDA Urban Agriculture grant and key elders were contracted to elevate the program and strengthen safety and participation amongst students. The garden expanded from 6 to 12 beds with Sergio's help and the MLK Garden was recognized as a USDA People's Garden, which are registered gardens that use sustainable practices that benefit people and wildlife and teach about gardening and resilient, local food systems.



Freedom Schoolers at
Black Queen Bee Honey Farm



2022 in Review

Organizing Farmers Across the United States



In 2022 Alita began working with the National Young Farmers Coalition as the Land Organizing Director . In this role she helped organize 100 farmers through the organization's land fellowship to empower them with education about federal policy, tools for how to speak to their congressional leaders, and organized a 3 day fly-in event with over 120 people to make a big splash on capitol hill! Alita incorporated several new farmer centric strategies into the land fellowship, contributed to several podcasts on the farm bill, and led several workshops related to organizing for federal policy changes to support farmers with land access.

2023 in Review

Shaping the Future through Intentional, Accessible Programming

The impact of Freedom School and the MLK Community Garden on our community have been rich. We had a **90% retention rate for our children's programming** and an ever increasing desire from other families wanting to get involved in the only programming of its kind in the area. We've been able to engage more families in the Let's Grow workshops at the garden as well. Providing opportunities for all commitment and experience levels through our thoughtfully curated programming.



Some of the **experiences facilitated through our work** with the Parks department in 2023 included:

- How to pickle + can produce from the Garden
- How to build planters from wood + small power tools
- Food Justice Principles
- Gardening 101
- Ancestral Food Heritage
- Seed keeping
- Healthy Food Demonstrations
- **Several Community Listening Sessions**
- Beekeeping
- Environmental Justice
- Intersectional Justice + Liberation
- Composting and more!



This is just a small sample of what we've brought to **over 250 participants** last year. All offerings have been free to the public and intentional outreach was done in the MLK Park neighborhood. Most of the paid facilitators were local, BIPOC community members.

2024 + beyond

Downtown Grand Rapids Inc

Jade Rabbit is currently commissioned to support the downtown development authority of Grand Rapids with their first community garden project. The goal is to increase access to healthy food through neighbor run garden plots, technical assistance, and education opportunities. Jade Rabbit has helped DGRI to plan this project and executes the technical assistance and educational workshops with help of other community partners.

Access of West Michigan

Jade Rabbit is currently supporting an ambitious collaborative project between Access of West Michigan, New City Neighbors, and Plainsong Farm to increase access of healthy, local foods to the rural areas of Kent County. Jade Rabbit is the group's strategic planner and is coaching partners through every step of the way to ensure that values are central to operation and efficient systems are in place to serve residents of Kent County to the best of the group's ability.

Strategic + Business Planning for Farmers

Jade Rabbit is contracted through the Michigan Food and Farming Systems to work with small to mid sized farms do strategic planning and business planning to support farmers' business goals and prepare them for whatever is next. For some its loans, land purchases, marketing revamps, grant writing, etc. Outside of this specific engagement we also working to support businesses, non-profits, and organizations of all kinds think through intentional planning for whatever success looks like in their field.

Grant Writing

Jade Rabbit serves as both grant reviewers and grant writers. We believe serving as both puts us in a unique position to do either one from an informed space. We work with clients to tell their stories in a captivating way and compel the communities support for whatever project we are advocating for. Our dedication to taking on only value aligned work serves as a sound foundation for communicating genuinely and in a manner that produces abundant results.

Scope of Work

Jade Rabbit will collaborate with Stellar Roots to develop a comprehensive business plan. The process will begin in July with monthly meetings to ensure steady progress and alignment of goals. Starting in October, meetings will shift to a bi-weekly schedule to intensify the efforts and ensure timely completion. The collaborative efforts will culminate by the second week of November. The main objectives include outlining a sustainable model for an intentional community, leveraging historical context, cooperative ownership, and integrating outreach and community support systems. Emphasis will be placed on culturally aware and inclusive practices, especially towards Black queer women.

Key Activities:

1. **Initial Planning and Research:** Collecting historical data and current operational insights, understanding land stewardship practices, and identifying stakeholder needs.
2. **Stakeholder Engagement:** Facilitating discussions with the community, indigenous groups, and cooperative members to gather feedback and insights.
3. **Model Development:** Crafting a new model for intentional community living that incorporates cooperative ownership and sustainable practices.
4. **Drafting Business Plan:** Structuring and writing a detailed business plan.
5. **Review and Finalization:** Iterative reviews of the draft document, incorporating feedback from stakeholders and experts, and finalizing the business plan.

Budget

Initial Monthly Meetings (Jul-Sep)

3 meetings x \$150 per meeting | **\$450**

Bi-Weekly Meetings (Oct-Nov)

6 meetings x \$150 per meeting | **\$900**

Research and Planning

Compilation and analysis of historical and current data | **\$800**

Stakeholder Engagement

Conducting interviews, workshops, and feedback sessions | **\$600**

Drafting Business Plan

Writing, structuring, and designing the business plan | **\$1,800**

Review and Finalization | Iterative reviews and up to 3 revisions | \$700

Total | \$5,250

This budget ensures that we will have the necessary resources to cover all phases of the project, from initial research to the final presentation of the business plan. Each phase is designed to build on the last, ensuring a thorough and well-considered plan that supports the sustainable growth and mission of Stellar Roots.

In gratitude + solidarity

Thank you

